The Hollywood Secret to Aging Beautifully

The Daily Habits of the Stars Who Stayed Sharp, Strong and Gorgeous Past 80, 90 and 100

A gift from the Behind the Fame YouTube channel

Please read this first

This book is for information and enjoyment. It is not medical advice. The stars in these pages had their own doctors, their own genes, and sometimes a great deal of money. Before you begin any new exercise, change your diet, or start a supplement, please talk to your own doctor, especially if you have heart disease, diabetes, osteoporosis, a history of falls, or take prescription medicines. Nothing here replaces that conversation.

The stories come from the stars' own books, interviews, documentaries, and news reports. Where the record is unclear, we tell you.

Welcome

Every week on our channel we open the files on the stars you grew up with. The secret marriages. The feuds. The fortunes that vanished. The last days.

But there is another kind of secret that we rarely get to tell, because it does not fit in a forty-minute video.

It is the secret of the ones who *lasted*.

Betty White was still making America laugh at ninety-nine. Dick Van Dyke was dancing on a desk in a movie at ninety-one and lifting weights at a hundred. Sophia Loren came back to the screen at eighty-six and stole the picture. Olivia de Havilland sued a television network at a hundred and one. June Squibb got her first leading role at ninety-

four and did her own stunts on a mobility scooter. Iris Apfel signed a modeling contract at ninety-seven.

These were not people who got lucky and sat still. When you look closely at how they lived, day by day, you find the same handful of habits again and again. Small ones. Cheap ones. Habits you can begin tomorrow morning in your own kitchen.

That is what this book is about.

Each chapter opens with one star and the story of how she, or he, really lived. Not the glamour, the routine. What time they got up. What they ate. How they moved. What they did when the phone stopped ringing, when a husband died, when the eyes or the knees gave out. Then we stop and look at what modern science says about that habit, in plain English. And each chapter ends with **three things you can do this week**.

Along the way you will find out which legend ate hot dogs for breakfast, which one has done the same twelve-minute exercise routine since the 1960s, which one gets up at

three in the morning to pray, and which one got her first tattoo at eighty-one.

At the back of the book you will find **The Stars' Morning**, a one-page routine built from their habits, and a gentle **30-Day Plan** that adds one small change at a time.

You do not have to do all of it. Betty White certainly didn't. Pick what fits your life. Keep what works.

And if a chapter reminds you of a star we should cover on the channel, or a habit of your own that has kept you going, please tell us in the comments. That is how our community grows.

With warmth,

The Behind the Fame team

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Part One: Keep Moving

Chapter 1. Dick Van Dyke, 100: “Keep moving”

In December 2025, Dick Van Dyke turned one hundred years old.

Think about what that means. He was born in 1925, the year *The Great Gatsby* was published. He was a teenager during the Depression and a young man in the Second World War. He danced with cartoon penguins in *Mary Poppins* in 1964, the same year the Beatles landed in New York. And more than half a century later, in *Mary Poppins Returns*, a ninety-one-year-old Dick Van Dyke climbed up on a desk and danced. No stunt double. No trick photography. The crew stood up and applauded.

So how does a man get to a hundred with that kind of spring in his step?

He has been asked this question thousands of times, and his answer never changes. It is two words long. He even used it as the title of his book: *Keep Moving*.

Here is what that looks like in practice.

Three mornings a week, Dick and his wife Arlene go to the gym. Not a celebrity gym with a personal trainer waiting at the door. A regular gym, where he does what he can. Some weights. Some time on the machines. Time in the pool, because the water carries the weight that his knees no longer want to.

The rest of the week, he moves anyway. He sings every day with his barbershop group. He dances in the kitchen while the coffee is brewing. He has said, more than once, that the secret is simply to not sit down for too long. “Keep moving,” he says, “and keep a positive attitude.”

Now, you should know that Dick Van Dyke was not a saint. In his younger years he smoked heavily and drank far too much. He talked about it openly and he got help. The point is that he did not use his past as an excuse. He stopped, and then he kept moving.

There is one more piece of the Van Dyke secret, and it may be the most important. In 2012, at the age of eighty-six, he married Arlene Silver, a makeup artist he had met at an awards show years before. She was forty years old. The newspapers had a field day. He didn't care. "I have a wife who is beautiful, and brilliant, and funny," he told interviewers, "and I have no idea why she married me, but I'm not going to question it." Arlene is the one who gets him to the gym. She is the one who films him dancing. They laugh together all day long.

Dick Van Dyke, at a hundred, is not alone. He is not sitting in a chair waiting. That, as much as the pool and the weights, is why he is still here.

What this means for you

The science behind "keep moving" is now overwhelming, and it is good news for anyone who has never been athletic in her life.

You do not need to run or sweat. Researchers who follow older adults for years find that the biggest difference in health and in how long people live is between

people who do almost nothing and people who do *a little*. Going from zero to a daily walk of twenty or thirty minutes brings a bigger benefit than going from a walk to a marathon. Light activity, like housework, gardening, and getting up to make tea, counts too.

Sitting is the problem. Long stretches of sitting slow your circulation, stiffen your joints, raise your blood sugar, and weaken the muscles that keep you from falling. The cure is not a gym membership. It is standing up every half hour or so, even for one minute.

Water is a gift to painful joints. Dick Van Dyke is right about the pool. In water up to your chest, your body weighs about a quarter of what it does on land. Many YMCAs, senior centers, and community pools offer gentle water exercise classes designed for people over sixty-five, and many Medicare Advantage plans and programs like SilverSneakers pay for them.

A companion matters. People who exercise with a spouse, a friend, or a class stick with it far longer than

people who try alone. If you have no one, the class *is* the companion.

Three things to do this week

1. **Set a “stand up” rule.** Every time a commercial break starts, or every time you finish a chapter of a book, stand up. Walk to the window and back. That is all.
2. **Find your water.** Call your local YMCA, senior center, or parks department and ask about water exercise or “aqua fitness” for seniors. Ask if your insurance covers it. Many plans do, at no cost.
3. **Dance in the kitchen.** Put on one song you loved when you were twenty. Move however your body allows, holding the counter if you need to. One song, every day. Dick Van Dyke does it at a hundred. You can do it today.

Chapter 2. Helen Mirren: The twelve-minute secret from the 1960s

Helen Mirren became a sex symbol at the age of sixty-three.

That is not a typo. In 2008, a photograph of her in a red bikini on an Italian beach went around the world. She had just won the Academy Award for *The Queen*. Magazines that normally put twenty-year-olds on their covers suddenly wanted to know what this English actress in her sixties was doing to look like that.

Her answer disappointed them.

She did not go to a gym. She did not have a trainer. She did not follow a diet. What she had, she admitted, was a photocopied exercise plan from the Royal Canadian Air Force that she had picked up in her twenties and had been doing, on and off, ever since.

The plan was designed in the late 1950s for airmen and their wives stationed on remote bases, where there was no equipment and very little room. It takes about twelve

minutes. You do it on your bedroom floor. There are only a handful of movements: touching your toes, raising your knees, circling your arms, a gentle version of a sit-up, and a few minutes of running or walking in place. The whole point is that it is so short and so simple that you have no excuse not to do it.

“It’s the exercise I’ve been doing forever,” she said. “It’s twelve minutes, and it just about keeps you going.” She has been honest that she does not do it every day. She does it when she remembers, when she feels herself getting stiff, when a film role is coming up. Then she drops it for a while. Then she picks it up again. For sixty years.

That is the real secret, and it is a kind one. Helen Mirren has never been perfect about exercise. She has simply never *quit*.

There is a second Mirren secret, and it is about words. She refuses to use the phrase “anti-aging.” She calls it “pro-aging.” She has said that she does not want to look younger; she wants to look like the best version of a woman her age. When a cosmetics company hired her to

sell face cream at seventy, she insisted that her wrinkles stay in the photographs. “I’m not going to pretend,” she said.

And one more thing. When she is asked what advice she would give her younger self, Helen Mirren does not say moisturize. She says, “Be more bloody-minded.” Say no to the people who tell you what a woman your age should do, wear, or want.

What this means for you

The Royal Canadian Air Force plan has been studied, copied, and sold in dozens of editions for sixty years. The reason it works is not that it is special. It is that it is *short*. The best exercise routine in the world does nothing if you don’t do it, and a twelve-minute routine beside your bed gets done.

Short daily sessions beat long weekly ones. Your heart, your balance, and your blood sugar respond to what you did today, not to what you did last Saturday. Ten or fifteen minutes every morning does more for an older body than

an hour once a week, and it is far less likely to leave you sore or injured.

Consistency is forgiving. Notice that Mirren drops the routine and comes back. Studies of older adults show that fitness built over years returns quickly after a break. Missing a week, or a month, is not failure. It is a pause.

A routine you can do in your nightgown has no barriers. No car, no membership, no special clothes, no weather. That is why it lasts.

Your own twelve minutes

Here is a gentle version of the idea, built for a woman over sixty-five. Do each movement slowly for about a minute, then move to the next. Hold the back of a chair whenever you want. Stop if anything hurts. Check with your doctor first if you have a heart condition or have had a fall this year.

1. **March in place.** Lift your knees as high as is comfortable. Swing your arms.

2. **Reach and bend.** Stand tall, reach both arms toward the ceiling, then bend gently toward your knees. Only as far as feels good.
3. **Arm circles.** Arms out to the sides. Small circles forward, then backward.
4. **Side bends.** One hand on the chair. Slide the other hand down your leg, come back up, switch sides.
5. **Sit to stand.** Sit on a sturdy chair, stand up without using your hands if you can, sit back down. Repeat. This single movement is one of the best predictors of independence in old age.
6. **Heel raises.** Holding the chair, rise onto your toes, lower slowly.
7. **Leg swings.** Holding the chair, swing one leg gently forward and back. Switch.
8. **Seated twist.** Sitting, hands on your shoulders, turn your upper body gently left, then right.
9. **Wall push.** Hands on a wall, elbows bend, push away. A push-up for people who do not do push-ups.
10. **March again.** A little faster if you can.

11. **Balance.** Hold the chair with one finger, then try none. Stand on one foot for a few seconds, switch.
12. **Breathe.** Stand or sit, hands on your belly, five slow breaths in through your nose and out through your mouth.

That is twelve minutes. That is Helen Mirren's secret. The only hard part is tomorrow morning.

Three things to do this week

1. **Pick your spot.** Choose the place beside your bed or in your living room where the routine will happen. Put a sturdy chair there and leave it.
2. **Do it three times.** Not seven. Three mornings this week, before breakfast, before you have a chance to talk yourself out of it.
3. **Be bloody-minded.** The next time someone says "at your age," decide for yourself whether they are right.

Chapter 3. Jane Fonda: A new hip, a new knee, and the exercise every woman over 65 needs

In 1982, a forty-four-year-old actress put on a striped leotard and leg warmers and changed how American women exercised.

Jane Fonda's Workout became the best-selling home video of all time. For years, in living rooms across the country, millions of women got down on the carpet and did leg lifts to her voice. "Feel the burn." If you are reading this, there is a fair chance you were one of them.

What almost nobody knew was that the woman on the screen was hiding an eating disorder that had haunted her since she was a teenager. She has written about it with painful honesty. Bulimia. Decades of punishing her body. "I was not a healthy person," she said. The workout craze, she admitted later, was partly a way of controlling a body she did not love.

Here is the part that matters for you. Jane Fonda is now in her late eighties, and she is in many ways healthier than

she was in that leotard. And the way she exercises has completely changed.

She has had a hip replaced and a knee replaced. She has had cancer, twice, and spoken openly about chemotherapy at eighty-five. She has arthritis in her back. The high-kicking aerobics of 1982 are long gone. What she does instead, she told readers in her book *Prime Time*, is simple and unglamorous. She walks. She stretches. And, above all, she lifts weights.

“The most important thing,” she has said again and again, “is strength training.” Not to look good. To stay upright. Because Jane Fonda understood something that most women are never told: the reason old people fall, break a hip, and never come home from the hospital is not bad luck. It is muscle. Muscle that quietly disappears, year after year, unless you ask it to stay.

So she lifts. Light weights, slowly, a few times a week. She does exercises for her balance. She does them at home. She has filmed some of them for people who cannot

afford a gym, and in them she is honest: “I’m slower than I was. I use lighter weights. But I do it.”

There is one more Fonda habit worth knowing. In her eighties, she stopped drinking alcohol, because, she said, it affects an older body far more than a younger one and she wanted her evenings and her mornings back. And at eighty-one she was arrested on the steps of the Capitol, protesting for the climate, and spent a night in jail. She said it was the most alive she had felt in years.

What this means for you

Jane Fonda is talking about something with a medical name: **sarcopenia**, the loss of muscle with age. It begins in your thirties and speeds up after sixty. By seventy, an inactive woman may have lost a third of the muscle she had at forty. That is why a jar lid becomes impossible, why getting up from a low sofa becomes a project, why a stumble on a rug becomes a fall instead of a wobble.

The good news is almost unbelievable: **muscle comes back at any age.** Studies of people in their eighties and nineties, some living in nursing homes, show that after a

few weeks of simple strength exercises their legs grow measurably stronger, they walk faster, and some who needed a walker no longer do. There is no age at which this stops working.

Falls are the thing to fear, not weights. One in four Americans over sixty-five falls each year. Falls are the leading cause of injury and injury-related death in that age group. Strength and balance training is the single most effective thing you can do to prevent them. It is more effective than any pill.

Your bones listen to your muscles. When a muscle pulls on a bone, the bone gets denser. That matters for every woman at risk of osteoporosis, which, after sixty-five, is most of us.

You need protein to build it. Older bodies need more protein than younger ones, not less, roughly 25 to 30 grams at each meal, which is an egg or two plus a cup of Greek yogurt, a palm-sized piece of fish or chicken, or a cup of beans with cheese. Many older women eat far too little. More on that in Part Two.

Strength training without a gym

You need two cans of soup, or two water bottles, and a sturdy chair. Do each movement eight to twelve times, slowly. Rest. Do the set again. Two or three days a week with a day of rest in between. Start lighter than you think and add weight only when twelve feels easy.

- **Sit to stand** from a chair, no hands. The king of exercises for independence.
- **Heel raises**, holding the counter.
- **Bicep curls** with your cans.
- **Overhead press**, cans up from your shoulders to the ceiling.
- **Wall push-ups.**
- **Standing leg lifts**, to the side and to the back, holding the chair.
- **Balance**: stand on one foot while you brush your teeth, hand near the sink. Switch feet halfway.

Many community centers run free or very low-cost classes based on this exact idea. Look for names like “Tai Chi for

Arthritis," "A Matter of Balance," "Stay Active and Independent for Life," or "EnhanceFitness." Tai chi, in particular, has been shown to cut falls by a third or more. Your local Area Agency on Aging can tell you what is near you; call the national Eldercare Locator at 1-800-677-1116.

Three things to do this week

1. **Try the sit-to-stand test.** Sit in a kitchen chair, arms crossed. Count how many times you can stand up and sit down in thirty seconds. Write the number down. In a month, do it again.
2. **Buy nothing.** Fill two water bottles. Keep them by the television. Do curls and presses during one program.
3. **Ask one question.** At your next appointment, ask your doctor: "Should I be screened for osteoporosis, and is strength training safe for me?" Medicare covers the bone density test.

Part Two: Eat Like a Star

Chapter 4. Sophia Loren: “Everything you see I owe to spaghetti”

It is the most famous thing Sophia Loren ever said, and she swears she never said it.

“Everything you see, I owe to spaghetti.” The line has been printed on posters, aprons, and the walls of Italian restaurants for sixty years. Loren has laughed about it in interviews. She did not say it, she insists. But she has never really denied the spirit of it, because the truth is close enough.

Sophia Loren grew up hungry. She was born in 1934 in a charity ward in Rome, to a mother who was not married, and raised in Pozzuoli, a poor town near Naples, during the war. There were nights when there was nothing to eat.

She was so thin that the children called her “the toothpick.” She has said that she never forgot what an empty plate feels like, and that is why she has never, in all her years of fame, gone on a diet.

So what does she actually eat?

She wrote a whole book about it in 1984, *Women & Beauty*, and the answer is almost disappointingly simple. She eats the way her grandmother ate in Pozzuoli. Pasta, yes, nearly every day, but a small plate of it, not a trough. Olive oil on everything. Tomatoes, greens, beans, fish, a little cheese. Fruit for dessert. Bread, but good bread. A glass of wine with dinner, sometimes. Nothing from a box.

And one rule above all: she stops eating when she is satisfied, not when she is full. In her town, she said, nobody could afford to be full.

But the real Loren secret is not on the plate. It is in the bedroom, and it is sleep.

Sophia Loren goes to bed early and she sleeps for nine hours. She has said this plainly for decades: “I need nine

hours, and I take them.” She gets up early, often before six, and the first thing she does is walk. Not a power walk. A long, quiet walk, forty-five minutes or so, before the day starts. Then she stretches. Then breakfast.

She has also always been strict about one thing that American women of her generation were not: the sun. She did not bake on beaches. She wore hats. She stayed in the shade when she could.

And her attitude? Sophia Loren has a line about that too, and this one she does admit to: “Nothing makes a woman more beautiful than the belief that she is beautiful.”

In 2020, at eighty-six, she returned to the screen in *The Life Ahead*, directed by her son, playing an old woman who takes in an orphan. Critics called it the performance of her life. She was walking before dawn every morning of the shoot.

What this means for you

Doctors have a name for the way Sophia Loren eats, and it is probably the most studied diet in the world: the

Mediterranean diet. Olive oil, vegetables, beans, fish, whole grains, nuts, fruit, small amounts of meat and dairy, and wine in moderation. Large studies, including one that followed thousands of older Spaniards for years, found that people who ate this way had fewer heart attacks and strokes, kept their memory longer, and were less likely to develop dementia. It is not a diet. It is a way of eating that you can keep for the rest of your life, which is the only kind that works.

You do not have to give up pasta. The problem in the American version is the portion, the cream sauce, and the garlic bread, not the noodle. A cup of pasta with olive oil, tomatoes, and a handful of beans or a piece of fish is a Mediterranean meal.

Older women need more protein, not less. As we said in the last chapter, your body needs protein to keep muscle. Loren's beans, fish, eggs, and cheese do that job. Make sure something with protein is on your plate at every meal, including breakfast.

Drink before you are thirsty. After sixty-five the sense of thirst grows weaker. Many older women walk around mildly dehydrated, which causes tiredness, dizziness, confusion, and falls. A glass of water with every meal and one in between is a simple rule.

Nine hours is not laziness. Most adults over sixty-five need seven to eight hours of sleep, and some need nine. Poor sleep is tied to memory loss, falls, depression, weight gain, and heart disease. If you snore loudly, wake up gasping, or are always tired despite being in bed long enough, ask your doctor about sleep apnea. It is common after menopause and very treatable.

The morning walk does double duty. Light in the morning sets your body clock, which helps you sleep at night. The walk itself strengthens your heart and your legs. Doing it before breakfast, as Loren does, is fine, but take a glass of water first.

Three things to do this week

1. **Switch your fat.** Put a bottle of olive oil beside the stove and use it instead of butter or margarine for cooking and on vegetables and bread.
2. **Protect your sleep.** Choose a bedtime and keep it for seven nights. No screens in the last hour. Keep the room dark and cool.
3. **Eat until satisfied.** At one meal a day, put your fork down halfway through and ask: am I still hungry? Wait a minute before you answer.

Chapter 5. Betty White: Hot dogs, French fries and vodka

Let’s get the scandalous part out of the way.

Betty White ate hot dogs. She ate French fries. She loved red licorice and kept a bag of it nearby. She drank vodka, and she did not pretend otherwise. When a reporter asked the eighty-nine-year-old star of *Hot in Cleveland* for her

diet secret, she grinned and said: “I don’t have one. I eat whatever I want.”

She died on December 31, 2021, seventeen days before her hundredth birthday, still working, still beloved, still sharp.

So should you go out and buy hot dogs?

No. And Betty would be the first to tell you so. Because when you look past the funny answer, the way Betty White actually lived is one of the most useful blueprints in this book.

Start with the hot dogs. Betty ate one, not three. She ate small, simple meals and she did not snack her way through the day. She never weighed much more than she did as a young woman, and she never struggled with it, because she did not *think* about food. It was not her enemy and it was not her comfort. It was lunch.

Now look at what she did with her days.

She worked. For eighty years, almost without a break. She was on television in 1939, before most Americans owned a set. She got her most famous role, Rose on *The Golden*

Girls, at sixty-three, the age when most women were being pushed out the door. She hosted *Saturday Night Live* at eighty-eight after fans started an internet campaign. She was still filming at ninety-eight. “Retirement,” she said, “is not in my vocabulary.”

She did crossword puzzles every day. Not occasionally. Every day, in ink, and she was quick about it.

She moved. She lived for decades in a two-story house, and when people asked about her exercise she said: “I have a two-story house and a very bad memory, so I’m up and down those stairs all day long.” She was joking, and she was not.

She loved animals more than she loved most people, and she said so. She worked for the Los Angeles Zoo for more than fifty years. She was on the board of the Morris Animal Foundation. There was always a dog in the house, and a dog gets you up in the morning and out the door whether you feel like it or not.

And she laughed. Constantly. At herself most of all. When her husband, the game show host Allen Ludden, died in

1981, she was fifty-nine. She never remarried. Asked why, she said, “Once you’ve had the best, who needs the rest?” She lived forty more years as a widow and spent them surrounded by friends, colleagues, and work.

That, not the vodka, is the secret of Betty White.

What this means for you

Being a little overweight after 65 is not the danger. Being frail is. Here is something your doctor may not have told you. In adults over sixty-five, study after study finds that people who are slightly heavier than the charts recommend live *longer* than people who are underweight. Unintentional weight loss in an older woman is a warning sign, not an achievement. Crash diets strip away muscle, not fat, and leave you weaker. Betty White never dieted, and she never lost her strength.

Eat enough. Many women over seventy quietly stop eating properly. They live alone, cooking for one feels pointless, appetite fades, teeth or dentures make chewing a chore. The result is slow starvation that looks like “just

getting older.” If you have lost weight without trying, if your clothes are loose, tell your doctor.

Humor is medicine, and that is not a figure of speech. Laughter lowers stress hormones, eases pain, and improves blood flow. People who rate themselves as having a strong sense of humor live longer, in studies that followed thousands of Norwegians for fifteen years. Betty White’s refusal to take herself seriously was doing real work inside her body.

A pet is a daily prescription. Older adults who own dogs walk more, have lower blood pressure, and are less lonely. The simple structure of a creature who needs feeding at seven and walking at eight is worth more than most people realize. If a dog is too much, a cat, a bird, or even regular visits with a neighbor’s dog count.

Purpose keeps you here. People who feel they have a reason to get up in the morning, whether it is work, grandchildren, a garden, a church, or a volunteer job, have lower rates of heart disease, stroke, dementia, and death.

Betty White had a reason to get up every morning for a hundred years.

Three things to do this week

1. **Check your protein, not your weight.** For three days, notice whether every meal has something with protein in it: eggs, milk, yogurt, cheese, beans, fish, chicken, nuts. If dinner is tea and toast, add a boiled egg.
2. **Do one puzzle in ink.** A crossword, a word search, a sudoku. Every day this week. In pen, like Betty.
3. **Find your dog.** If you have a pet, walk it one extra time a day. If you don’t, ask a neighbor if you can walk theirs, or look up whether a local shelter needs volunteers to sit with the animals. Many do.

Chapter 6. Martha Stewart: The green juice, the garden and the swimsuit at 81

In May 2023, *Sports Illustrated* put an eighty-one-year-old woman on the cover of its swimsuit issue.

It was Martha Stewart, in a white one-piece and a flowing orange wrap, on a beach in the Dominican Republic. She was the oldest cover model in the magazine's history by nearly two decades. The photograph went around the world, and a great many women over sixty looked at it and asked the obvious question.

How?

Martha's own answer was blunt, as usual. "I didn't starve myself," she said. "I didn't go on a diet. I just kept doing what I do." What she does, it turns out, is very specific, and most of it has nothing to do with vanity.

She gets up at six. The first thing she does, every single morning, is make a green juice. She has described it a hundred times: a handful of spinach, a few stalks of celery,

half a cucumber, a piece of fresh ginger, some parsley, maybe an orange or an apple to take the edge off, through the juicer, drunk standing up in the kitchen. She has been doing it for years. “It’s the best thing I do for myself,” she says.

Then she goes outside. This is the part that people miss. Martha Stewart has a farm in New York, and she works it. She gardens, hard. She lifts bags of soil, prunes trees, plants bulbs on her knees in the cold. She has horses and rides them. She has dogs, cats, chickens, peacocks, and all of them need feeding. On a normal day she walks miles without ever calling it a walk.

Three times a week she does Pilates, a slow strengthening exercise that works the deep muscles of the back and stomach. She started it in her sixties because her back hurt. She credits it, more than anything, with keeping her upright.

And she eats what she grows. Her meals are built from her own vegetables, her own eggs, and fish. She does not drink much, and she is suspicious of sugar. But she also makes

cakes for a living and eats a slice when she wants one. “Moderation,” she says, “is not the same as deprivation.”

One more thing. Martha Stewart was sixty-two when she went to federal prison for five months. Her company nearly collapsed. Her marriage had ended years earlier. She came out, went back to work, and twenty years later was on the cover of *Sports Illustrated*. When asked how she got through it, she did not mention juice. She said: “I just kept busy. I never stopped.”

What this means for you

You do not need a farm, a juicer, or a magazine cover. But Martha Stewart’s routine happens to contain three of the best-studied habits in the science of aging.

Gardening is one of the healthiest things an older woman can do. It is strength training, balance training, and cardio disguised as a hobby. Studies of older gardeners find lower rates of heart disease, better hand strength, better bone density, less depression, and lower rates of dementia. It gets you into sunlight, which sets your sleep clock and makes vitamin D. It gives you a reason to go

outside tomorrow. And it is almost free. If you do not have a yard, a few pots of tomatoes and herbs on a step, a windowsill, or a raised bed at a community garden will do.

Dark leafy greens may protect your memory. A long-running study in Chicago followed nearly a thousand older adults for years and found that those who ate about one serving of leafy greens a day, spinach, kale, collards, lettuce, had brains that functioned as if they were eleven years younger than those who rarely ate them. You do not need a juicer. A handful of spinach stirred into eggs, soup, or pasta, or a salad at lunch, does the same job, and keeps the fiber that juice throws away.

Your core keeps you off the floor. Pilates, yoga, and tai chi all strengthen the deep muscles around your spine and belly that hold you upright when you trip. Many senior centers and YMCAs offer gentle “chair Pilates” or “chair yoga” classes. Ask.

Sugar is the thing to be suspicious of, not fat. Added sugar in sodas, sweetened coffee, cereal, and packaged snacks raises blood sugar, feeds inflammation, and is tied

to heart disease and memory loss. Martha’s cake once in a while is not the problem. The daily sweet tea is.

Three things to do this week

1. **Plant something.** A pot of basil on the windowsill. A tomato on the porch. Three bulbs in the yard. Something that will need you next week.
2. **Add a handful of green.** Buy one bag of spinach. Put a handful into whatever you are cooking, every day, until it is gone.
3. **Find the sugar.** Read the label on three things you eat every day. If the first line says sugar, corn syrup, or anything ending in “-ose,” swap one of them for something that doesn’t.

Part Three: Skin, Hair and Style

Chapter 7. Joan Collins: The one thing she refused to do for seventy years

When Joan Collins walked onto the set of *Dynasty* in 1981 as Alexis Carrington, she was forty-eight years old, which in Hollywood terms made her a senior citizen. The network had wanted someone younger. Within a year she was the most-watched villain on American television, and the shoulder pads, the furs, and the cheekbones were on the cover of every magazine in the supermarket.

Four decades later, at ninety-two, she is still working, still married, and still asked the same question at every interview: what is the secret of her skin?

She has given the same answer for fifty years, and people still refuse to believe it.

She stayed out of the sun.

“I never sunbathed,” she says. “Never.” She grew up in England, where there wasn’t much sun to begin with, but when she arrived in California in the 1950s she watched her fellow starlets roasting themselves beside swimming pools and decided not to. Her mother had told her it would ruin her skin. Her mother was right. By the 1970s, Joan Collins was wearing wide hats, sitting under umbrellas, and putting on sunscreen before anyone called it that. She still does. She has said she will not go into the sun without a hat and a cream, and if you look at photographs of her at any beach or pool in the last fifty years, you will see the hat.

The rest of her routine is almost boringly simple, and she wrote it all down in *The Joan Collins Beauty Book* in 1980. Cleanse gently, never scrub. Moisturize every morning and every night, “like brushing your teeth.” Drink water. Get sleep. Don’t smoke. Eat small meals and don’t

fill up on junk. She keeps her weight steady by eating “a bit of everything and not too much of anything.” She has a glass of wine but not three.

Does she wear makeup? Of course. She has never pretended to go bare-faced, and she has never claimed that her face at ninety is the work of nature alone. But she has also said, often, that she does not understand women who spend fortunes on creams and then lie in the sun for a week in Florida.

One more Joan Collins habit. She has never stopped working. Books, columns, stage tours, television, a one-woman show in her eighties. In 2002, at sixty-eight, she married Percy Gibson, a theater producer thirty-two years younger. When people raised eyebrows about the age difference, she had a ready answer: “If he dies, he dies.”

What this means for you

Dermatologists have a number for the Joan Collins secret. Something like **eighty to ninety percent of the visible aging of the face**, the deep wrinkles, the brown spots, the sagging, the rough texture, is caused by the sun, not by the

calendar. Doctors call it photoaging. The proof is on your own body: compare the skin on the inside of your upper arm, which has rarely seen the sun, with the back of your hand.

Here is the part that matters at sixty-five and beyond. **It is not too late.** Skin that is protected from the sun begins to repair itself. Studies show that people who start using sunscreen daily, even late in life, have measurably less new damage and fewer precancerous spots within a year.

Skin cancer is the most common cancer in America, and it is most common in people over 65. Most of it is curable if found early. Once a year, let a doctor look at your whole skin, including your scalp and the backs of your legs. Between visits, watch any spot that is new, changing, bleeding, or not healing.

Older skin is thinner and drier. After menopause, skin loses oil and collagen. It bruises more easily and heals more slowly. This is why Joan's "cleanse gently" matters. Hot water, harsh soap, and scrubbing strip what little oil is left. Lukewarm water, a mild cleanser, and a thick

fragrance-free moisturizer applied while the skin is still damp are the whole routine. Petroleum jelly on the hands and feet at night, under cotton gloves or socks, works better than most expensive creams.

A hat beats a cream. Sunscreen is important, but it wears off and gets missed. A wide-brimmed hat and long sleeves do not. Wear them in the garden, on walks, and in the car, where the side window lets through the rays that cause the most damage.

Smoking ages skin faster than anything except the sun. If you still smoke, quitting at any age improves your skin, your lungs, and your odds. Medicare covers help to quit. Call 1-800-QUIT-NOW.

A word about hair

Hair thins after menopause in most women, and that is normal. A few things help: a gentle shampoo, not every day; a wide-toothed comb on wet hair; iron and thyroid levels checked by your doctor if the loss is sudden; and eating enough protein, because hair is made of it. Many women find that a shorter, lighter cut makes thin hair look

fuller than long hair ever could. As for gray, Jane Fonda, Helen Mirren, and Andie MacDowell have all stopped coloring and said they wished they had done it sooner. It is a choice, not a surrender.

Three things to do this week

1. **Put a hat by the door.** A real one, with a brim. Wear it every time you go outside in daylight, starting today.
2. **Move your moisturizer.** Put it next to your toothbrush. Use it, on your face and your hands, every time you brush. Morning and night, like Joan.
3. **Book the look.** Call your doctor or a dermatologist and ask for a full skin check. If it has been more than a year, it is time.

Chapter 8. Iris Apfel: A fashion model at ninety-seven

In 2019, one of the biggest modeling agencies in the world, the one that represents the supermodels you see on magazine covers, signed a new client.

She was ninety-seven years old.

Her name was Iris Apfel, and she had never been a model, an actress, or a singer. For most of her life she ran a fabric company with her husband Carl, restoring curtains and upholstery for old houses, including nine times for the White House. She was known, if at all, to interior decorators.

Then, in 2005, when she was eighty-four, the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York had a hole in its schedule. A show had fallen through. Somebody remembered that Iris Apfel had a closet, or rather a whole apartment, full of the most extraordinary clothes and jewelry anyone had ever seen. Couture jackets worn with flea-market beads. Fur with plastic bangles stacked to the elbow. Enormous round

glasses. Colors that should not go together and somehow did.

The museum put her closet on display. The show was supposed to be a filler. It became one of the most popular exhibits the museum had ever held, and an eighty-four-year-old woman with white hair and giant black spectacles became, overnight, the most famous face in fashion.

She was on magazine covers at ninety. She had a documentary made about her at ninety-three. She designed a line for a department store at ninety-four. She signed the modeling contract at ninety-seven. She died in March 2024, at a hundred and two, with a closet still full of plans.

Her philosophy fit on a T-shirt, and in fact it was printed on one: **“More is more, and less is a bore.”**

But under the beads, there was a sharper message, and it is the one that matters here. “I don’t do pretty,” she said. “Pretty is boring. When you are young, you are pretty because you are young. After that, you have to be *interesting*.” And: “If you are not interested, you are not interesting.” She read. She traveled into her nineties. She

went to parties. She learned new things on purpose. She was, in her own words, “the world’s oldest living teenager.”

And she had a rule about mirrors. She did not look in them to find fault. She looked in them to decide what to put on next.

What this means for you

This chapter has no diet and no exercise in it, and it may be one of the most useful chapters in the book.

How you dress changes how you feel, and how you feel changes your health. Psychologists call it “enclothed cognition”: putting on clothes that you associate with confidence, competence, or joy actually changes your mood, your posture, and even your performance on tests. Older women who make the effort to dress every day, rather than staying in a housecoat, report less depression and more energy. It is not vanity. It is self-respect, and it works from the outside in.

Color lifts mood. There is real research on this. Bright, saturated colors raise alertness and happiness, and they also make you more visible to drivers, which matters after sixty-five, when most pedestrian deaths occur. Iris Apfel's scarlet coat was a safety device.

"Interesting" protects your brain. We will say more about this in Part Four, but people who stay curious, who learn new things and seek out new experiences, build what scientists call cognitive reserve, a kind of cushion against memory loss. Boredom, not age, is the enemy.

The one thing to be careful about is your feet. This is the only place where fashion and safety fight, and safety should win. Floppy slippers, backless shoes, high heels, and smooth-soled flats cause a large share of the falls in older women. A good shoe has a low heel, a closed back, a sole that grips, and room for your toes. It can also be red.

The Iris Apfel wardrobe test

Open your closet. Ask yourself three questions:

1. **What have I not worn in a year?** It is taking up room that something joyful could have.
2. **What do I feel good in?** Put it where you can reach it. Wear it on an ordinary Tuesday.
3. **What is one thing I have always wanted to wear and never dared?** A red lipstick. A big necklace. A hat. Buy it. Wear it this week. Iris would.

Three things to do this week

1. **Get dressed every day,** even if no one will see you. Shoes on. One piece of jewelry.
2. **Check your shoes.** Line them up. Any pair with a loose back, a worn sole, or a heel higher than an inch and a half goes to the back of the closet or to charity.
3. **Do one interesting thing.** A museum, a library talk, a new recipe, a bus to a part of town you have never visited. If you are not interested, you are not interesting.

Part Four: A Sharp Mind

Chapter 9. Olivia de Havilland: A crossword every morning, a lawsuit at 101

In 2017, a television network aired a series about the feud between Bette Davis and Joan Crawford. In it, a character named Olivia de Havilland gossiped about her fellow stars and called her sister a “bitch.”

The real Olivia de Havilland was a hundred and one years old, living in Paris, and she was not having it.

She sued. She said she had never spoken that way about anyone, that the show had put words in her mouth, and that it had damaged her reputation. Her lawyers asked the court to hurry, given her age. The network’s lawyers argued that it was fiction and free speech. The case went up through the California courts. She lost, in the end, but that was not

really the point. The point was that the last surviving star of *Gone with the Wind*, Melanie Wilkes herself, at a hundred and one, was still in full command of her mind and her temper and was not going to be pushed around.

She died in 2020, at a hundred and four. So what was going on inside that head for all those years?

Olivia de Havilland did a crossword puzzle every morning. Every morning. In English, which by then was her second language of daily life, because she had moved to Paris in the 1950s and spoke French at home. She read constantly, newspapers and novels and history. She wrote a book about living among the French. She answered her own letters, in longhand, into her nineties. She served as a reader at her church, the American Cathedral in Paris, standing at the lectern to read scripture aloud well into old age.

When she turned a hundred, reporters asked for her secret. She gave them three words, which she called the three L's: **love, laughter, and light**. Love, meaning her children and her friends. Laughter, meaning she refused to be grim

about anything, including her famous lifelong feud with her sister, Joan Fontaine. And light, which some took to mean faith and some took to mean simply getting out into the sun. She did not explain. She enjoyed letting people wonder.

She also, for the record, enjoyed champagne. A glass on special occasions. At a hundred and four, every day is a special occasion.

What this means for you

Olivia de Havilland, without meaning to, was running a textbook program for what scientists now call **cognitive reserve**. The idea is simple. A brain that has been kept busy, challenged, and connected for a lifetime builds extra pathways. When age or disease starts to damage it, the brain has spare roads to drive on. People with high cognitive reserve can carry the same amount of physical damage as people with low reserve and show far fewer symptoms. Some are found, at autopsy, to have had advanced Alzheimer’s disease and never showed a sign of it in life.

Here is what builds it, in order of how strong the evidence is.

Learning a second language. De Havilland lived her life in two languages. People who speak two languages develop dementia, on average, about four years later than people who speak one. It is never too late to start, and the struggle itself is the exercise. A free app, a community class, or a conversation group at the library all count.

Reading and puzzles. People who do crosswords, read, and play word or number games regularly in late life show slower memory decline, and in some studies the onset of memory problems is delayed by years. The key word is *regularly*. One puzzle a week does little. A puzzle every morning, like Olivia's, is a habit.

Hearing. This one surprises people. Untreated hearing loss is now considered the largest single changeable risk factor for dementia. A brain that strains to hear has nothing left for memory, and a woman who cannot follow conversation withdraws from it. A major American trial published in 2023 found that older adults at risk of decline who were

fitted with hearing aids slowed their mental decline by almost half over three years. Medicare Advantage plans often cover hearing aids now, and good ones are sold over the counter for a fraction of the old price. If people say you have the TV too loud, get your hearing tested.

Reading aloud, writing by hand, and social roles. Standing at a lectern in church, writing letters, being the one who organizes the family dinner: all of these keep multiple parts of the brain working together, and they tie you to other people, which protects memory more than any puzzle.

And the three L's are not just a slogan. Love, meaning close relationships, is the strongest predictor of healthy aging in the longest-running study of adult life ever done, at Harvard. Laughter we covered with Betty White. Light, meaning daylight, sets your sleep, lifts depression, and makes the vitamin D your bones and brain need.

Three things to do this week

1. **Start the puzzle.** Buy a book of crosswords or word searches at the drugstore, or use the free one in the newspaper. One every morning, with your coffee. Ink optional.
2. **Test your hearing.** Many pharmacies and audiologists offer free screenings, and there are free hearing tests online. If you have trouble in restaurants or with the telephone, do not wait.
3. **Learn ten words.** Pick a language you have always liked the sound of. Learn ten words this week. Say them out loud to someone.

Chapter 10. Kirk Douglas: The stroke that took his voice at 79

In January 1996, Kirk Douglas was sitting in his home in Beverly Hills having a manicure when he felt something strange in his face. He tried to speak to the manicurist. The words came out as gibberish.

He was seventy-nine years old. He was Spartacus. He was the man with the chin, the jaw, the unmistakable growling voice that had filled movie theaters for fifty years. And in a few seconds, the voice was gone.

The stroke had hit the part of his brain that makes speech. He could think clearly. He understood everything. But when he opened his mouth, nothing usable came out. For a man whose whole life had been talking, it was, he wrote later, like being buried alive.

He has been honest about what happened next. He sank into a depression so deep that he took out a gun and put it in his mouth. What stopped him, he said, was that the barrel hit a bad tooth and the pain made him laugh at the absurdity of it. He put the gun away. And then he went to work.

Speech therapy, every day. Slow, humiliating exercises, repeating sounds like a child. Physical therapy for the weakness on one side. He started swimming. He got a trainer. Two months after the stroke, he walked onto the stage at the Academy Awards to accept an honorary Oscar,

and he spoke. Slowly, thickly, but he spoke. The audience wept.

Then he did something that nobody expected. He wrote a book about it, *My Stroke of Luck*, and the title was not a joke. He said the stroke had been the best thing that happened to him, because it had forced him to slow down and to become, for the first time in his life, a decent husband and father.

He lived twenty-four more years. In those years he wrote ten books. He gave away most of his fortune, well over a hundred million dollars, to build hundreds of playgrounds in Los Angeles schools, a homeless shelter, and an Alzheimer's unit at a hospital. He and his wife Anne, married since 1954, celebrated their sixtieth anniversary and then their sixty-fifth. At a hundred and one, he was still doing his exercises. He died in February 2020, at a hundred and three, with his voice, and his humor, still with him.

What this means for you

Stroke is the fifth leading cause of death in the United States and the leading cause of serious long-term disability. **Women are more likely than men to have a stroke, more likely to die from one, and more likely to be left disabled.** After sixty-five, the risk doubles every ten years. This chapter may be the most important one you read.

Know the signs. They spell FAST.

- **F, Face.** Ask the person to smile. Does one side droop?
- **A, Arms.** Ask them to raise both arms. Does one drift down?
- **S, Speech.** Ask them to repeat a simple sentence. Is it slurred, strange, or missing?
- **T, Time.** If you see any of these, call 911 immediately. Note the time it started.

Women sometimes have different warning signs: sudden confusion, sudden severe headache, sudden trouble seeing, sudden dizziness or loss of balance, sudden numbness on

one side, or sudden exhaustion and nausea. The word to remember is *sudden*.

Time is brain. The clot-busting drugs and procedures that can reverse a stroke work only within the first hours. Every minute without treatment, millions of brain cells die. Do not call your daughter. Do not lie down and see if it passes. Do not drive yourself. Call 911, and say the word "stroke," so the ambulance takes you to a hospital equipped for it.

Most strokes are preventable. The causes are not mysterious. High blood pressure is the biggest, and it has no symptoms, which is why it must be measured. Then atrial fibrillation, an irregular heartbeat that is common after sixty-five and often silent. Then diabetes, high cholesterol, smoking, and sitting still. Every one of these is something your doctor can find and treat. A blood pressure check, a listen to your heart, and a blood test once a year do more to prevent a stroke than anything you can buy.

Recovery is real, at any age. Kirk Douglas got his speech back at seventy-nine because he did the therapy. The brain

rewires itself after injury, and it does so in response to practice. If you or your husband has a stroke, ask for rehabilitation and do every exercise they give you, every day, for as long as they tell you. Medicare covers it.

Depression after a stroke is common and treatable. One in three stroke survivors becomes depressed. It is not weakness. It is a change in the brain. Tell the doctor. It is one of the most treatable conditions in medicine.

Three things to do this week

1. **Learn FAST.** Write “Face, Arms, Speech, Time: call 911” on a card and put it on your refrigerator. Teach it to your husband, your children, and your neighbor.
2. **Know your blood pressure number.** If you do not know it, have it checked this week. Most pharmacies will do it for free. If it is over 130 on top, talk to your doctor.
3. **Ask about your heartbeat.** At your next visit, ask: “Have you ever checked me for atrial

fibrillation?” Many smartwatches and blood pressure monitors can now detect it at home.

Chapter 11. Judi Dench: She can no longer read a script. She memorizes them anyway.

For her eighty-first birthday, Dame Judi Dench got a tattoo.

Her daughter gave it to her as a present. It is on the inside of her wrist, two words in Latin: *Carpe Diem*. Seize the day. She shows it to interviewers with the delight of a teenager who has gotten away with something.

She had reasons to want the reminder. Nine years earlier, in 2012, she had announced to the world that she had macular degeneration, the eye disease that slowly destroys the center of your vision. It is the most common cause of vision loss in people over sixty-five. It does not make you blind, exactly. It takes away the part of your sight that you

use to read, to recognize faces, to see what is right in front of you.

For an actress, that means you cannot read a script.

Most people would have retired. Judi Dench was seventy-seven and had won an Oscar, a dozen other awards, and a title from the Queen. Nobody would have blamed her.

Instead, she changed how she worked. Friends and family read her scripts aloud to her, line by line, and she memorizes them by ear, the way actors did before there was printing. On set, someone describes where the furniture is. She has said she can no longer see the faces of the actors she is talking to, so she works from their voices. In this way, with almost no central vision, she filmed *Belfast* at eighty-six and was nominated for another Academy Award at eighty-seven.

“I don’t want to retire,” she has said. “I don’t believe in it. The word is not in my vocabulary.” Asked how she keeps going, she said something that should be written on the wall of every doctor’s office: “The more you do, the more you can do.”

She has also been clear about what keeps her mind sharp. She does the crossword, like Olivia de Havilland, with someone reading the clues. She learns poems by heart, for the pleasure of it, and recites them to friends. She keeps a close circle: her daughter, her grandson, her longtime partner, and old friends from the theater, who come for lunch and stay for hours. Her husband, the actor Michael Williams, died in 2001, and she has said that the loneliness afterward was the hardest thing she has faced. The cure, she said, was to keep saying yes. Yes to the part. Yes to the lunch. Yes to the tattoo.

What this means for you

Macular degeneration is common, it is not the end, and some of it is preventable. Roughly one in ten Americans over sixty-five has some stage of it. The dry form, which is most cases, moves slowly. The wet form moves fast and can be treated with injections that preserve sight, but only if it is caught early. The warning signs are straight lines that look wavy, a blurry or dark spot in the center of what you see, and faces that are hard to recognize. If you notice any of these, do not wait for your next appointment.

A yearly eye exam does more than check your glasses. It can catch macular degeneration, glaucoma, which steals vision from the edges without any symptoms, cataracts, which are easily fixed with surgery, and diabetes, which shows up in the back of the eye before anywhere else. Medicare covers a yearly eye exam for people with diabetes, and the glaucoma test for people at risk. If you have no coverage, ask your eye doctor about programs for seniors; many exist.

What you eat shows up in your eyes. The same leafy greens we met in Martha Stewart's kitchen, spinach, kale, and collards, are rich in two pigments that protect the retina. Fish rich in omega-3 fats, like salmon and sardines, helps too. For people who already have middle-stage macular degeneration, a specific vitamin formula, usually labeled AREDS 2, has been shown to slow it down. Ask your eye doctor before buying any supplement.

The sun ages your eyes the way it ages your skin. Sunglasses that block ultraviolet light, worn outdoors, reduce the risk of cataracts and macular damage. Cheap ones work as well as expensive ones if the label says UV

400 or 100 percent UV protection. Joan Collins' hat helps here too.

Losing sight does not have to mean losing your life. Judi Dench's trick of memorizing by ear is available to anyone. Free audiobooks and talking newspapers are available from the National Library Service for the Blind and Print Disabled, through your public library. Large-print books, magnifiers, and phones that read aloud have never been better or cheaper. The question is not whether you can still read. It is whether you will keep saying yes.

Three things to do this week

1. **Take the grid test.** Look at a sheet of graph paper, or the tiles on a bathroom wall, with one eye covered, then the other. If straight lines look bent, wavy, or have gaps, call an eye doctor this week.
2. **Book your eyes.** If it has been more than a year since an eye doctor looked at the back of your eyes, make the appointment.

3. **Learn a poem.** Pick a short one you loved in school. Learn it by heart over seven days. Say it to someone on Sunday. Carpe diem.

Chapter 12. Goldie Hawn: Ten quiet minutes a day for fifty years

Goldie Hawn has been laughing on screen for nearly sixty years. The giggle, the wide eyes, the ditzy blonde from *Laugh-In* who turned out to be anything but. At eighty, she still posts videos of herself dancing in the kitchen with the same joy.

So it surprises people to learn that the happiest woman in Hollywood built her life around a battle with fear.

In 1972, Goldie Hawn was twenty-six, had just won an Academy Award, and was so anxious that she could barely leave the house. She has described panic attacks that came out of nowhere, a feeling that she was losing her mind, and a terror that fame had taken her away from herself. She went to a doctor. The doctor suggested something that in

1972 sounded strange: sit quietly, close your eyes, and breathe.

She learned to meditate. And she has done it every day since. More than fifty years.

“It saved my life,” she has said, without exaggeration. Ten minutes in the morning, sometimes more. Eyes closed, attention on the breath, letting thoughts pass. She is not precious about it. She does it in hotel rooms, on airplanes, in the back of cars. She has said that when she skips it, she feels the difference by lunchtime.

In her fifties she became so convinced of what it had done for her that she started a foundation to teach a simple version of it to schoolchildren. The program is now in thousands of classrooms. She wrote a book, *10 Mindful Minutes*, explaining how to do it. She has argued, on talk shows and to scientists, that the single most useful thing a person can learn is how to calm her own mind.

A few other Goldie Hawn habits, for the record. She has been with Kurt Russell since 1983 without ever marrying him, and she says the secret to forty years together is

“being kind, and going to bed friends.” She walks every day. She does a little weightlifting. She lifts her face to the sun in the morning. And she dances, often, badly, in her kitchen, because, she says, “joy is a practice.”

What this means for you

Goldie Hawn’s doctor was fifty years ahead of medicine. Today, sitting quietly and paying attention to your breath for ten minutes a day, which doctors call mindfulness meditation, is one of the best-studied habits in all of health research, and it is particularly powerful after sixty-five.

It lowers blood pressure. Enough that the American Heart Association has said meditation may be a reasonable addition to treatment for people with high blood pressure.

It eases anxiety and depression. In large reviews of the research, a daily meditation practice works about as well as medication for mild to moderate anxiety and depression, with no side effects. Depression in older women is common, under-diagnosed, and often mistaken for “just getting old.” It is not. It is treatable, and this is one of the treatments.

It improves sleep. Older adults who learned mindfulness in a six-week class slept better than those who took a sleep education class, in a study at the University of California. For a woman who lies awake at three in the morning with her mind racing, that is not a small thing.

It may protect memory. Early research suggests that people who meditate regularly keep more gray matter in the parts of the brain that handle attention and memory. The evidence is still young, but the direction is clear.

It reduces pain. Not by making it go away, but by changing how the brain responds to it. For arthritis, back pain, and the aches that come with age, people who practice mindfulness report needing less medication.

And it costs nothing, requires no equipment, and can be done in a chair.

Your ten minutes

1. Sit in a chair with your feet on the floor and your hands in your lap. Set a kitchen timer for five

minutes to start. Ten when you are ready.

2. Close your eyes, or lower them to the floor.
3. Notice your breath. Do not change it. Just feel the air come in and go out. Feel your belly rise and fall.
4. Your mind will wander. To the grocery list, to your daughter, to a worry. That is not failure. That is what minds do. When you notice, gently bring your attention back to the breath. Each time you do this, you are doing a repetition, like a bicep curl for your attention.
5. When the timer rings, open your eyes. Sit for a moment before you get up.

That is the whole thing. There is no trick and nothing to buy. Goldie Hawn has done exactly this, more or less, every morning for fifty years.

If you would like a voice to guide you, your public library may offer free access to meditation apps, and many senior

centers and hospitals offer free mindfulness classes for older adults. Some Medicare Advantage plans cover them.

Three things to do this week

1. **Five minutes, three mornings.** Timer, chair, breath. Before the news, before the phone.
2. **Go to bed friends.** If you share your life with someone, do not let the sun go down on an argument this week. Goldie’s rule.
3. **Face the morning sun.** For two minutes, outside or at an open window, let the light hit your face. It sets your clock, lifts your mood, and costs nothing.

Part Five: The Heart and the Spirit

Chapter 13. Rita Moreno: The night she nearly gave up, and the habit that saved her

In 1961, Rita Moreno was about to become the first Hispanic woman ever to win an Academy Award, for playing Anita in *West Side Story*. She was twenty-nine, beautiful, and famous.

She was also, that year, at the end of an eight-year love affair with Marlon Brando that had left her, in her own words, “a shell.” He had cheated, humiliated her, and come back, over and over. She had let him. One night, alone in his house, she swallowed every pill she could find.

His assistant found her. She woke up in a hospital. She has written about it, in her memoir, with the plain honesty that makes her who she is: “I wanted to die. I’m very glad I didn’t.”

What happened after is the real story.

Rita Moreno went into therapy, and stayed in it, for most of her life. Not for a few sessions. For decades. She has said, to anyone who will listen, that talking to a professional, week after week, is the reason she is alive, the reason her marriage of forty-five years to a cardiologist named Leonard Gordon worked, and the reason she was able to raise a daughter without passing on the wounds of her own childhood. “Therapy saved my life,” she says. “Everyone should have it.”

Then she went back to work, and she never stopped. She won a Grammy. Then a Tony. Then two Emmys. She became one of only a handful of people in history to win all four. At eighty-six she was starring in a television comedy. At eighty-nine she was back in a new *West Side Story*, sixty years after the first one, and she executive-

produced it. She has a tattoo of a rose, acquired in her seventies. She still dances, in her kitchen and sometimes on stage.

Asked at ninety what keeps her going, she listed three things. Work: “I never want to stop.” Friends: she has a close circle of women she has known for fifty years, and they talk constantly. And honesty, about her feelings, about her failures, about the past: “I don’t keep secrets anymore. Secrets make you sick.”

What this means for you

Rita Moreno is talking about mental health, and she is talking to a generation of women who were taught never to.

Depression is not a normal part of aging. It is a medical condition, and it is common after sixty-five, especially in women, especially after a loss, a move, a diagnosis, or retirement. It often does not look like sadness. It looks like tiredness that sleep doesn’t fix. Loss of appetite. Aches that doctors cannot explain. Trouble concentrating. Not caring about things that used to matter. Snapping at people.

Many older women are treated for the aches and never asked about the rest.

Older women are at real risk. Suicide rates rise with age, and the loss of a spouse is one of the biggest risk factors. If you have ever thought that your family would be better off without you, please tell someone. You can call or text **988**, the national crisis line, any hour of any day. It is free, and the person who answers has heard it before.

Talking works, and Medicare pays for it. Psychotherapy, the kind Rita Moreno has done for sixty years, is as effective as medication for most depression in older adults, and the two together are better than either alone. Medicare Part B covers visits with psychologists, clinical social workers, and counselors. Many now see patients by telephone or video, which means no driving. Ask your doctor for a referral, or call your Medicare plan and ask for a list of mental health providers in your area.

Secrets make you sick. The science agrees. People who carry shame, grief, or old wounds without ever speaking them have higher levels of stress hormones, more

inflammation, worse sleep, and more heart disease. Writing about a painful experience for fifteen minutes a day, for a few days, in a notebook nobody will read, has been shown to improve immune function and mood. It is one of the oddest and most repeated findings in psychology.

Friends are medicine. We will say more in the next chapter, but Rita's circle of women friends of fifty years is doing exactly what the Harvard study of adult life found to be the strongest predictor of health and happiness in old age: close relationships you can count on.

Three things to do this week

1. **Take the two-question test.** Over the past two weeks, have you often felt down, depressed, or hopeless? Have you had little interest or pleasure in doing things? If the answer to either is yes, tell your doctor at your next visit, or call for one.
2. **Write for fifteen minutes.** Pick one thing you have never talked about. Write about it in a

notebook for fifteen minutes, three days this week. Then put the notebook away or throw the pages out. Nobody needs to read them.

3. **Call the oldest friend you have.** Not text. Call. Rita’s circle did not keep itself.

Chapter 14. Dolly Parton: Three in the morning, 58 years of marriage, and what she does with her grief

Dolly Parton gets up at three o’clock in the morning.

Not sometimes. Every day. She has described her mornings many times, and they never change. She wakes at three without an alarm. She spends the first hour in what she calls “my time with God”: prayer, reading scripture, sitting quietly, thinking. Then she makes coffee and writes, songs, mostly, and ideas for the dozen businesses she runs. By the time the rest of the world wakes up, Dolly has done a full day’s work.

She says she needs only a few hours of sleep, and that she has always been this way. Her doctors would probably prefer she slept more, and we would say the same. But what matters is not the hour. It is what she does with it. Every day begins with quiet, with faith, and with purpose, before anyone can ask her for anything.

As for food: “I eat a little of everything and not a lot of anything.” She has never been on a diet that lasted. She grew up one of twelve children in a one-room cabin in Tennessee, and like Sophia Loren, she has never forgotten what hunger is. She keeps her portions small, she loves the Southern food she grew up on, and she refuses to feel guilty about any of it.

And then there is Carl.

On May 30, 1966, a twenty-year-old Dolly married Carl Dean, an asphalt contractor she had met outside a Nashville laundromat on her first day in the city. He never went to her shows. He never gave interviews. For fifty-eight years, while she became one of the most famous women on earth, he ran his business, mowed the lawn, and

waited for her to come home. The tabloids spent decades insisting the marriage was a fake. It was not. “He’s the only man I ever loved,” she said, “and the only one who ever loved me for me.”

Carl Dean died on March 3, 2025. He was eighty-two.

Dolly was seventy-nine. The world braced for her to disappear.

Instead, within days, she had released a song she had written for him, and she kept working. She was honest about the pain: she said she cried every day, that the house was too quiet, that she talked to him. But she also said something that every widow in America understood. “I have to keep busy. If I sat still, I don’t know what I’d do.” She threw herself into the thing that has given her life meaning beyond music for thirty years: the Imagination Library, the program she started in 1995 in memory of her father, who could not read, which mails a free book every month to any child who signs up, from birth to age five. It has now sent out well over two hundred million books. She has said it is the thing she wants to be remembered for.

Faith, in the dark before dawn. Small portions and no guilt. A love that lasted fifty-eight years. And when it ended, a purpose bigger than the grief.

What this means for you

This chapter is about the two things that, according to the longest and best studies of old age, matter more than any diet or exercise: **purpose** and **connection**. And it is about what to do when one of them is taken from you.

Purpose adds years. People who say they have a clear reason to get up in the morning, in studies that follow thousands of older adults for a decade or more, have lower rates of heart attack, stroke, dementia, and death, after accounting for everything else. The purpose does not have to be a charity that mails out two hundred million books. It can be a grandchild who needs picking up, a garden that needs watering, a church that needs a reader, a neighbor who needs a ride, a dog. What matters is that something, or someone, depends on you tomorrow.

Faith and community protect health. People who attend religious services regularly live longer, on average, than

people who do not, and the effect is stronger in women. Researchers believe it is the combination of quiet reflection, hope, a built-in community that notices when you are missing, and a reason to leave the house. If church is not your place, the same benefits come from any community that meets every week and expects you to show up.

Grief is physical, and the first year is dangerous. Widowhood raises a woman's risk of death in the following months, especially from heart disease. Doctors call it the widowhood effect, and one cause is a real condition, sometimes called broken heart syndrome, in which the shock of loss weakens the heart muscle. It mostly affects women over sixty. It feels like a heart attack and should be treated as one: chest pain or shortness of breath in the weeks after a loss is an emergency. The other causes are simpler. Widows stop eating, stop sleeping, stop taking their pills, and stop going out. Dolly's "keep busy" is wise, as long as it includes eating, sleeping, and letting people in.

Grief does not have to be carried alone. Hospices offer free bereavement support groups to anyone in the community, not only to families of their patients. Churches run them. So do senior centers. Talking to other women who have lost husbands, in a room, once a week, is one of the most effective things a widow can do for her health. If the grief does not lift at all after a year, or if it comes with thoughts of not wanting to go on, it may have become depression, which the last chapter covered, and which is treatable.

Do not make big decisions in the first year. Do not sell the house, move in with a child, give away money, or remarry in the first twelve months unless you must. Grief clouds judgment, and people who want to help, and people who want to take advantage, both appear in the first weeks.

Three things to do this week

1. **Claim your first hour.** Whatever hour you wake, keep the first thirty minutes for yourself: coffee,

prayer, a book, the window, quiet. No phone, no news, no one else's needs.

2. **Name your purpose.** Finish this sentence, on paper: "Tomorrow, someone or something needs me to…" If you cannot finish it, choose something small this week that will need you: a plant, a weekly call to a grandchild, a volunteer shift.
3. **If you have lost someone, find the room.** Call a local hospice and ask about bereavement groups open to the community. You do not need to have used their services. You just need to show up once.

Chapter 15. June Squibb: Her first leading role at 94

June Squibb spent sixty years as the woman you almost recognized.

She was in Broadway choruses in the 1950s. She played mothers, grandmothers, nurses, neighbors, and the lady in the next hospital bed in dozens of movies and television

shows. She was good. She was reliable. She was never the star. At eighty-four, she was nominated for an Academy Award for playing a sharp-tongued farm wife in *Nebraska*, and most of the audience had to look her up.

Then, in 2024, a young director named Josh Margolin wrote a film about his own grandmother, who had nearly been fooled by a telephone scam. In the movie, a ninety-three-year-old widow named Thelma loses ten thousand dollars to a man pretending to be her grandson in trouble, and then, when her family and the police shrug, she sets out across Los Angeles on a borrowed mobility scooter to get it back herself.

He asked June Squibb to play Thelma. She was ninety-four. It was the first leading role of her life.

She did her own stunts. She rode the scooter. She climbed, she fell, she fired a gun on screen. The film was a hit, the reviews called it the performance of the year, and a ninety-four-year-old woman spent the summer on talk shows explaining that no, she had not thought it was too late, and no, she was not planning to retire. The next year, at ninety-

five, she starred in another film, directed by Scarlett Johansson, and the year after that she was still working.

Asked for her secret, she gave the least glamorous answer in this book. “I just keep working. I like it. I don’t know what I’d do if I didn’t.” She walks. She does a few exercises. She reads scripts, and she says yes.

And asked what she would tell a woman of eighty who thinks her best years are behind her, she said: “Well, that’s just silly.”

What this means for you

We end here on purpose, because the most common thing a woman over sixty-five believes about herself is also the most wrong: that it is too late. Too late to start exercising. Too late to learn something. Too late to make new friends, change her diet, take up painting, go back to school, fall in love, or matter.

The science says the opposite, loudly.

The brain keeps changing until the end. For most of the twentieth century, doctors believed the adult brain was fixed. We now know it grows new connections, and even new cells, in response to learning, at every age. The ninety-year-old who takes up the piano builds new pathways just as the nine-year-old does, more slowly, but just as surely. Learning something hard and new in late life is one of the best-documented protections against memory loss.

Muscle, bone, balance, and the heart all respond at every age. We saw it with Jane Fonda. Ninety-year-olds in nursing homes grow stronger with simple exercises. Women who start walking at seventy lower their risk of heart disease. It is never too late to start, and starting late is far better than never.

Attitude toward aging is itself a cause of aging. This is one of the strangest findings in the field. In a study at Yale, older adults who held positive beliefs about aging, who thought of old age as a time of wisdom and possibility rather than decline, lived on average seven and a half years longer than those with negative beliefs. Seven and a half

years, which is more than quitting smoking or losing weight buys you. The researchers believe it works through behavior: people who think it is not too late do the exercise, keep the friends, go to the doctor, and say yes to the part.

New friends are possible, and necessary. Many women over sixty-five have lost their circle to death, distance, and the end of work. Building a new one feels impossible. It is not. The recipe is the same at every age: show up at the same place, at the same time, every week, and talk to the same people. A class, a volunteer shift, a church group, a walking group, a library book club. Three months of Tuesdays makes a friend.

Where to start, for free or nearly free:

- **Osher Lifelong Learning Institutes** offer college courses for adults over fifty at more than a hundred universities across the country, with no tests and no grades.
- **Most states let residents over sixty or sixty-five audit or take community college classes free or at a**

steep discount. Call your local community college and ask.

- **AmeriCorps Seniors** places volunteers over fifty-five with schools, hospitals, and nonprofits, and some programs pay a small stipend.
- **Senior centers** are not what they were. Many now offer art studios, computer classes, tai chi, trips, and lunch for a dollar or two. Find yours through the Eldercare Locator, 1-800-677-1116.
- **Your public library** offers free classes, book clubs, language programs, audiobooks, and, increasingly, a librarian who will sit with you and explain your phone.

Three things to do this week

1. **Write down the thing.** The thing you always meant to do and decided was too late. Write it on a card. Put the card on the refrigerator, next to the FAST card.
2. **Take one step toward it.** One phone call. One class catalog. One brush. One lesson. Not the

whole thing. The first step.

3. **Say yes.** The next time someone invites you to something you would normally decline because of your age, your knees, or your hair, say yes. See what happens. June would.

At the Back of the Book

The Stars’ Morning

Here is what happens if you put the stars’ habits together into one ordinary morning. You do not need all of it. Pick three lines and do them for a month.

Time	Habit	Who taught us
On waking	Thirty quiet minutes before the world: prayer, a book, the window, five slow breaths.	Dolly Parton
Then	A glass of water. Your thirst is quieter than it used to be.	Sophia Loren
Then	Twelve minutes beside the bed: march, reach, sit-to-stand, heel raises, balance.	Helen Mirren

Time	Habit	Who taught us
Then	Two minutes with your face in the morning light.	Goldie Hawn
Breakfast	Something with protein: eggs, yogurt, cheese, nuts. A handful of greens if you can.	Jane Fonda, Martha Stewart
With coffee	One crossword or puzzle, in ink.	Betty White, Olivia de Havilland
Before going out	Moisturizer on face and hands. Hat on. Shoes with a back and a grip.	Joan Collins, Iris Apfel
Mid-morning	A walk. Twenty minutes, with a friend, a dog, or a song.	Dick Van Dyke
All day	Stand up every half hour. Dance to one song. Laugh at something.	Betty White
Evening	Dinner with olive oil, vegetables, beans or fish. Stop when satisfied.	Sophia Loren

Time	Habit	Who taught us
Before bed	No screens for the last hour. Go to bed friends. Aim for eight hours.	Goldie Hawn, Sophia Loren

Your gentle 30-Day Plan

One small change at a time. Each week adds one habit and keeps the ones before. If you miss a day, you have not failed. Helen Mirren has been missing days since 1965.

Week 1: Move

- Day 1. Do the sit-to-stand test. Write your number down.
- Day 2. Put a sturdy chair beside your bed. Do the twelve minutes, or as much as you can.
- Day 3. Start the “stand up every commercial” rule.
- Day 4. Twelve minutes again.
- Day 5. Walk for ten minutes outside, hat on.
- Day 6. Twelve minutes. Dance to one song.

- Day 7. Rest. Call a friend and tell her what you did this week.

Week 2: Eat

- Day 8. Put olive oil by the stove. Use it instead of butter today.
- Day 9. Add protein to breakfast. Keep the twelve minutes going three days this week.
- Day 10. A handful of spinach into something.
- Day 11. Read the labels on three foods. Swap one sugary one.
- Day 12. A glass of water with every meal and one between.
- Day 13. At one meal, stop halfway and ask whether you are still hungry.
- Day 14. Rest. Plant something in a pot.

Week 3: Protect

- Day 15. Put the moisturizer next to your toothbrush.
- Day 16. Line up your shoes. Retire the dangerous ones.

- Day 17. Write the FAST card and put it on the refrigerator.
- Day 18. Have your blood pressure checked at a pharmacy. Write it down.
- Day 19. Do the wavy-line eye test with each eye.
- Day 20. Book the appointments you have been putting off: skin, eyes, hearing, bone density.
- Day 21. Rest. Learn ten words in a new language.

Week 4: Connect

- Day 22. Five minutes of quiet breathing in a chair.
- Day 23. Call the oldest friend you have.
- Day 24. Five minutes of breathing. Finish the sentence: “Tomorrow, someone needs me to…”
- Day 25. Find one weekly thing to show up to: a class, a group, a walk, a service. Write down when it meets.
- Day 26. Write for fifteen minutes about something you have never said.
- Day 27. Get dressed, jewelry on, and do one interesting thing.

- Day 28. Go to the weekly thing.

Days 29 and 30

- Day 29. Do the sit-to-stand test again. Compare your number.
- Day 30. Write down the thing you always said was too late. Take the first step.

A note on talking to your doctor

Several chapters in this book end with a question to ask your doctor. Here they are in one place, so you can take the page with you.

- Should I be screened for osteoporosis? Is strength training safe for me?
- What is my blood pressure, and is it where it should be?
- Have you ever checked me for atrial fibrillation?
- Could any of my medications be making me dizzy, tired, or forgetful?

- I have lost weight without trying. Should we look into that?
- I have been feeling down or not interested in things. Can we talk about that?
- Could I have sleep apnea?
- Is it time for a full skin check, an eye exam, and a hearing test?
- Is the Medicare Annual Wellness Visit due? It is free, and it includes a check on memory, falls, and mood.

Medicare’s Annual Wellness Visit costs nothing and is the right place for every question on this list. If you have not had one in the last twelve months, that is the first phone call.

Numbers to keep by the phone

- **911** for stroke signs, chest pain, or any emergency.
- **988** the Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, call or text, any hour, for yourself or someone you love.

- **1-800-677-1116** the Eldercare Locator, to find your Area Agency on Aging, senior centers, exercise classes, meals, and help at home.
- **1-800-QUIT-NOW** (1-800-784-8669) free help to stop smoking.
- **1-800-MEDICARE** (1-800-633-4227) questions about what Medicare covers.
- **1-800-272-3900** the Alzheimer's Association helpline, 24 hours, for questions about memory, for yourself or a loved one.

A last word from the channel

Every star in this book is someone we have told stories about, or will. Their secrets, their heartbreaks, their last days. Those are the stories that bring people to our channel.

But these are the stories we are proudest to tell. Not how they fell, but how they kept standing. Not what they lost, but what they did every morning, for decades, to stay here.

None of them had a secret you cannot have. Sophia Loren’s nine hours of sleep are available to you tonight. Helen Mirren’s twelve minutes are waiting beside your bed. Betty White’s crossword is in tomorrow’s paper. Dolly’s quiet hour is yours at whatever time you wake. Iris Apfel’s red coat is in a store near you, and Judi Dench’s poem is in a book on your shelf.

If this book helped you, please tell us which chapter, and which star, in the comments of any of our videos. And if there is a star whose secret you would like us to open the files on, tell us that too.

Keep moving. Keep laughing. Keep saying yes.

The Behind the Fame team